COUNTRY REPORTS: ETHIOPIA

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Status report

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Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Ethiopia's strategy shelf is fuller than its delivery machinery. The overarching digital government strategy is current, while the whole-of-government transformation programme meant to deliver it is only planned or in draft, and the national data strategy has not been adopted (2025).

Digital Ethiopia 2030, issued from the Prime Minister's Office, designates data a national asset, names a national data exchange as a digital public infrastructure enabler and sequences its initiatives across nought-to-three and three-to-five year horizons; it also carries a target of a sevenfold rise in digital payments, delivered through Telebirr and a national payment gateway. Beneath it, the Digital Ethiopia Strategy held in the Ministry of Innovation and Technology's library covers artificial intelligence, the internet, cybersecurity, data centres and cloud services, data protection, digital identification, payments, digital signatures and e-commerce.

Ownership of delivery is dispersed. The Digital Government Strategy and Enterprise Architecture 2024–2029, a blueprint building on the strategy before it, went to final review in July 2024 ahead of submission for government approval, prepared by the Ministry of Innovation and Technology with European Union funding. An established data governance function takes a whole-of-government view of data rather than a system-by-system one, but sits inside another institution rather than having an autonomous body of its own (2025), alongside an established institution coordinating digital government.

The wider governance record behind all this is improving over the decade and slipping over the last few years of it: Ethiopia scores 48.4 out of 100 for overall governance in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, 29th of 54 African states, up 2.5 points over 2014–2023 but down 1.5 points over 2019–2023. It scores above the African average on 45 of the index's 96 indicators and improved on 55 of them over the decade while declining on 37.

The European Union committed EUR 1.2 million over 2020–2025 to the Ministry of Innovation and Technology for its role guiding and enabling digital reforms.

Legislation and regulation

Ethiopia's ban on virtual assets is wider than the cryptocurrency ban it is taken for: on 23 July 2026 the National Bank defined a virtual asset as any digital representation of value that can be electronically traded, transferred, exchanged or used for payment or investment, and confirmed that its use, purchase, sale, exchange, transfer, trading, settlement, facilitation, custody and administration remain prohibited without the Bank's express authorisation. The prohibition came by public notice rather than by regulation, and no enforcement mechanism was announced with it.

The flagship of digital government runs without a dedicated legal footing: MESOB operated for nearly a year without a dedicated regulatory framework, its Addis Ababa deputy director has called for a law compelling institutions to digitise before joining it, and its executives have sought clarity on which institution regulates the platform and answers for it (July 2026).

Telecommunications are governed by Directive No. 792/2021, made by the Ethiopian Communications Authority under the Communications Service Proclamation No. 1148/2019 and in force since 9 July 2021, which creates individual, class and spectrum licences. Only two individual licences exist, for unified telecommunications service and for an internet exchange point, and the class licences run from hosting and data centre services to VSAT, private networks and closed user groups. Individual licences run fifteen years, with a further fifteen presumed where the holder has met every obligation and applied three years before expiry, and any change of ownership taking a shareholder to twenty-five per cent or more needs the Authority's prior approval, refused where it judges the acquisition likely to be anti-competitive. The Directive also exempts the state incumbent from the competition it introduced: its new licence is issued without competitive selection, subject to re-assignment of its spectrum bands.

Copyright still rests on the 2004 proclamation, whose remedies run to sentences of one to ten years, fines of up to 25,000 Birr and injunctions; amendments are being drafted with legal experts from Addis Ababa University's law school (August 2026). A comprehensive personal data protection law has been on the books since July 2024. The Council of Ministers approved a draft national data management proclamation on 28 September 2026 and referred it to the House of Peoples' Representatives, framed around data security and sovereignty and data sharing across government systems.

Data protection

Ethiopia has a comprehensive data protection law and, more than a year after it was gazetted, almost nothing running under it: the secondary directives needed to operate Proclamation No. 1321/2024 had still not been issued as of November 2025, and no enforcement action by the Ethiopian Communications Authority had been made public as of March 2025. The proclamation was approved on 4 April 2024 and gazetted on 24 July 2024, replacing the country's piecemeal sectoral regulation of personal data.

It sets a broad definition of personal data, claims extraterritorial reach over foreign entities handling Ethiopians' data, and places significant obligations on controllers, requires controllers to notify both the Authority and affected data subjects within 72 hours of becoming aware of a breach, and obliges personal data to be stored locally — matching Digital Ethiopia 2030's principle of national anchoring for data, infrastructure and systems.

Supervision went to an existing regulator rather than to a purpose-built one: the proclamation designates the Ethiopian Communications Authority as the body responsible for supervising personal data protection, rather than creating a standalone data-protection authority. It is to register data controllers and processors and impose fines and compliance orders, but a year after the law its enforcement remained slow with implementing directives still awaiting approval (2025), and neither the regime nor the authority publishes reporting on how it operates (2025).

Sectoral protection is older and more concrete than the general regime. The National Bank of Ethiopia's Financial Consumer Protection Directive No. FCP/01/2020, in force since 25 February 2021, covers digital financial services including payments and mobile money, mandating key facts statements, transparency, data confidentiality, complaint handling and reimbursement for unauthorised transactions, and a revised Payment Instrument Issuer Directive in 2023 strengthened governance, transaction limits and consumer safeguards for mobile money providers.

Confidentiality also runs outward against disclosure: the Development Bank of Ethiopia's Information Disclosure Policy designates client credit information as not eligible for declassification, permanently withheld (August 2026). Ethiopia scores 16.0 out of 100 for digital freedom in 2023, 52nd of 54 African states and one of its ten worst-scoring indicators despite a 5.2-point improvement over the decade.

Regional collaboration

Regional integration is where Ethiopia has moved furthest and fastest: it is the country's second most improved indicator of the decade in the 2024 Ibrahim Index, up 33.8 points over 2014–2023 to 49.1 out of 100, 23rd of 54 African states.

The reach is physical before it is institutional. The Horizon Fiber agreement between Ethio Telecom, Djibouti Telecom and Sudatel became binding in February 2026, committing the three to a terrestrial fibre corridor linking Djibouti's cable landings through Ethiopia to Sudan's and positioning the country as a regional digital transit route. The corridor entered active deployment in August 2026, its route extended to Jeddah, and the three operators presented it to Google, Meta, Microsoft and Amazon, among carriers and equipment vendors, at a pre-commercialisation meeting in Addis Ababa on 7 September 2026.

Ethiopia joined the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System as its 31st member, reported on 30 September 2026, after delays over the government's concern that financial data would be exposed to other member countries; four Ethiopian banks await central bank no-objection letters before they can transact, and the central bank governor and the system's chief executive announced the membership jointly on 15 October 2026, opening the network to the country's financial institutions for cross-border payments. The national switch was separately integrating with the UAE's Aani system (November 2025). Ownership questions travel too: Vodacom's move to take a controlling stake in Safaricom required Ethiopian approval as well as Kenyan and South African, giving Ethiopian regulators a say over the consortium leader behind the country's second telecoms licensee.

The identity credential is being built to travel: the FaydaPass wallet was launched in 2025 as the programme adopted international wallet specifications and argued for cross-border recognition of national IDs.

Standards

Ethiopia's first mandatory cybersecurity standards were approved in April 2026: the national standards board approved five mandatory cybersecurity standards and 31 guidelines and frameworks on 24 April 2026, prepared by the security agency with the standards institute as the technical framework for the critical-infrastructure cybersecurity proclamation, with the texts still to be published. International standards come in through a standards institute that is an ISO member body and an IEC associate member, whose 2026 catalogue lists ISO/IEC 27000 on information security management, ISO/IEC 20546 on big data and ISO/IEC 2382 on information-technology vocabulary as Ethiopian Standards.

The rulebook by which Ethiopian government systems are meant to talk to each other is seven years old: the Ethiopian National Enterprise Architecture Framework and the Ethiopian eGovernment Interoperability Framework, both dating from 2019, are the standing interoperability instruments in the Ministry of Innovation and Technology's library.

A framework being in place is not the same as systems being built to it. Most of the supporting measures tested alongside the interoperability framework are recorded as not in place (2025), no government agency had yet been integrated with the planned national data exchange platform (March 2025), data remains fragmented across

agencies for want of clear data-sharing rules and standards, and MESOB's founding director general has conceded that the platform remains intertwined with institutions' systems, some decades old, built to undefined standards and unclear architectures (July 2026). There is also no open source policy for government (2025).

Procurement is the one place where standards bite on what is actually bought. The e-procurement system is in use across open tendering and contract management, interfaces with other government systems and is used to enforce technical standards on government purchases, and the Auditor General credits it with a decline in cash shortages across federal institutions. Where a sector has a sponsor, standard-setting follows: national livestock data standards were developed with the Ministry of Agriculture and formally endorsed (2026).

Compliance with the rules that do exist is patchy. The Office of the Federal Auditor General presented its EFY 2017 report to the House of People's Representatives on 6 July 2026, covering financial and compliance audits of 163 federal public institutions and 39 performance audits, and recorded repeated financial-rule violations — duplicate payments, expenditure above approved limits and disbursements without adequate supporting documentation — with a warning that authorising officials will be held to account and irregular disbursements recovered.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The media regulator has used its licensing power against independent outlets: it revoked Addis Standard's online media registration on 24 February 2026, a decision the publisher is challenging in court, and the outlet's editor-in-chief was detained and its newsroom raided in August 2026. Wazema Radio's licence was also revoked, and Addis Standard's managing editor was held incommunicado for two weeks in April 2026, after the media authority permanently suspended two Deutsche Welle correspondents covering Amhara and Tigray in December 2025.

Participation has improved faster than any other part of Ethiopia's governance record while the freedoms that give it force have gone backwards. Participation is the fastest-improving sub-category of the 2024 Ibrahim Index for Ethiopia, up 12.4 points over 2014–2023 to 41.9 out of 100, with civil society space up 13.8 points to 39.8, while media freedom fell 7.0 points to 34.1, 46th of 54 African states and rights is the worst-performing sub-category at 28.5, 44th of 54, down 4.7 points over the same decade. Ethiopians' own assessment of freedom of speech fell sharply over that decade, one of the country's five most deteriorated indicators.

The channels are in place. Government participation platforms operate, though several of the capabilities tested against them are not in place, citizen feedback channels carry complaints and feedback to government, and a right-to-information regime is in force under which members of the public can obtain public records, with nothing published on how it performs (2025). The justice ministry launched an online consultation platform and a manual for public and stakeholder participation in lawmaking in July 2024.

Draft copyright amendments have been through several rounds of consultation with rights holders, law enforcement and justice institutions, and what is described of them would add procedures for identifying and blocking websites, and a take-down notice obliging platforms to remove content on a rights holder's notification (August 2026), a site-blocking power arriving inside a copyright statute.

The same reticence runs through the digital estate: documentation and assessments across the service portal, e-procurement, the coordinating institution, the participation platforms and the feedback channels are held internally and not published. Domestic criticism is not absent — an Addis Ababa outlet has argued that the mandatory design of the national digital ID risks surveillance and exclusion — and the European Union committed just under EUR 1 million over 2023–2026 to mobilise civic and digital action against social media hate speech and online incitement to violence.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Ethiopia's own money, the treasury's and its agencies' retained revenue, carries 79.8 per cent of the digital lines in the 2026/27 federal budget as appropriated, ETB 35.2 billion of ETB 44.1 billion, against 78.4 per cent of ETB 25.0 billion in 2025/26.

The largest single line is fee income: the Immigration and Citizenship Service is to spend ETB 6.26 billion of its own retained revenue building a modern digital system in 2026/27, beside ETB 1.08 billion from the treasury, up from ETB 698 million of retained revenue in 2025/26. The same 2026/27 budget puts ETB 5 billion of treasury capital into an Artificial Intelligence University and ETB 3.05 billion into a national fibre project, and pays the Communications Authority's ETB 30.1 million data-protection line from its retained revenue.

The two largest systems are still paid from outside: the 2026/27 budget carries ETB 5.41 billion of assistance against ETB 300 million of treasury counterpart for the national identity project, and ETB 3.10 billion of assistance against ETB 5.7 million for the digital health system. The identity credit closes in January 2029; the World Bank's March 2026 mission recorded the programme being operationalised as a state-owned enterprise, FaydaVerse, as its framework for long-term sustainability, with ETB 10 billion of authorised and ETB 2.5 billion of paid-up capital inside Ethiopian Investment Holdings (March 2026). United States health-data funding tapers to US$1.26 million in 2030, with Ethiopia undertaking to meet licensing, cloud and hardware costs.

In 2024/25 the Ministry of Innovation and Technology spent ETB 990 million of its ETB 2.75 billion vote, 35.9 per cent, while the Digital ID for Inclusion programme, voted nothing, spent ETB 3.06 billion added in-year.

MoUs and other agreements

The Horizon Fiber memorandum of December 2024, between Ethio Telecom, Djibouti Telecom and Sudatel, became binding in February 2026, committing the three to a terrestrial fibre corridor running from Djibouti's cable landings through Ethiopia to Sudan's and casting Ethiopia as a regional transit route; it entered active deployment in August 2026.

Little else does. The December 2025 memorandum under the America First Global Health Strategy sets out a United States intention to fund Ethiopian health data systems over 2026 to 2030, on a declining annual schedule totalling under US$20 million, with Ethiopia undertaking to meet the software licensing, cloud, hardware maintenance and replacement costs itself; the memorandum records that it is not an international agreement, and the funding is subject to appropriations. On the domestic side, Safaricom Ethiopia has partnered with the National ID Program to run Fayda enrolment under Lots 3 and 4 (July 2026), adding a second telco-led registration channel.

New investments

The largest single live commitment on Ethiopia's digital record is not money to build anything with: MIGA's ten-year, US$1 billion political risk guarantee (2023–2033) covers the equity of Safaricom Telecommunications Ethiopia's shareholders — Vodafone, Vodacom, Safaricom Kenya and British International Investment — against expropriation, war and civil disturbance, with a US$76 million first-loss layer from the IDA20 Private Sector Window. It is cover for foreign investors' downside, not capital for a network.

Forty-three distinct external commitments to Ethiopia's digital estate are on record, announced since July 2015 on windows closing as late as 2036, and worth around US$3.3 billion on the headline figures — of which the guarantee is under a third; three carry no US dollar amount. Thirty-four sit in windows that have not closed; six are approved and not yet operating and one is still at pipeline stage. Eight were announced in 2025 or later, against sixteen in 2023 and 2024.

The European Union is the most frequent financier by count, with seven commitments, ahead of the World Bank on five and IFC, the Gates Foundation and the Mastercard Foundation on three each; twenty-two distinct financiers appear in all. By value the order inverts: the World Bank Group's three arms hold almost two-thirds of everything recorded. Grants are much the commonest instrument, twenty-two of the forty-three, but together carry less than the single guarantee. After connectivity, much the largest share, the money goes to ICT industry and startups, digital identity and training; payments and fintech draw many commitments but little money.

Behind the aggregates one asset keeps recurring. The consortium that won a fifteen-year telecoms operating licence in 2021 has since taken equity from British International Investment and from IFC, which also lent the operating company for 4G rollout and M-PESA, with a second IFC debt facility. Elsewhere the money is public and singular: the identity programme rests on one World Bank package, with its long-term financing plan not fully documented beyond revenue from card fees and authentication charges, while Korea's development fund rebuilds tax and customs IT to 2027. Private rounds are small by comparison: Better Auth, an authentication start-up founded in Addis Ababa, closed a US$5 million seed round in June 2025.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Data and internet passed mobile voice as Ethio Telecom's largest revenue line in the 2025/26 fiscal year, at 31.1 per cent of revenue against 23.5 per cent for voice. The operator closed 2025/26 with 52.5 million data and internet users, 1 million of them fixed broadband, and group revenue of 215.8 billion Birr, up 33.2 per cent, on 90.1 million subscriptions.

Subscriptions are not people. Unique mobile subscriber penetration rose from 26 per cent in 2020 to 33 per cent in 2024, far below the 68.4 per cent of the population that mobile connections, which count SIMs, reached in late 2025, and internet penetration stood at 19 per cent in 2024. International bandwidth was 22 kbit/s per internet user in 2022, and a mobile broadband basket cost 3.4 per cent of gross national income per head.

Build-out runs through vendor contracts and, newly, a second operator's own plant. Ethio Telecom signed network expansion agreements with Ericsson, ZTE, Huawei and Nokia at MWC 2026; by August 2026 4G reached 92 per cent of the population across ZTE's own footprint, with 124 new sites, 272 sites of spectrum refarming and 115 rural sites still outstanding. Safaricom Ethiopia began laying regional fibre of its own in August 2025, on an Afdera–Mekelle route. The Horizon Fiber corridor with Djibouti Telecom and Sudatel, binding since February 2026, entered active deployment in August 2026 on a route extended to Jeddah. Domestic traffic crosses one internet exchange point, Addix, with three members (2026).

What that reaches on the ground is thinner. A national maturity assessment of the community health information system, published in 2025, rated its ICT infrastructure at 1.67 out of 5, with 32 per cent of required tablets supplied and LAN internet coverage in health facilities at 28 per cent; ICT infrastructure is likewise the weakest domain of the national DHIS2 deployment (2024). Competition dates from 2021, when the Safaricom-led consortium paid US$850 million for a fifteen-year operating licence; its network passed 15 million 90-day active subscribers in September 2026, against the incumbent's 72.09 million active mobile subscribers at June 2026.

Data Storage

No hyperscale cloud provider has a region or an edge node in Ethiopia, the nearest hyperscale regions being in South Africa (2025), so anything requiring hyperscale capacity is served from outside the country while personal data carries a localisation requirement obliging local storage under the 2024 proclamation.

The in-country estate that has to absorb that is small and commercial. Raxio opened a Tier III-certified facility at the Addis Ababa ICT Park in November 2023 with room for 800 racks and up to 3MW of IT power, RedFox's first modular data centre went live at the same park in September 2022, the state operator's Huawei-built modular data centre at Gola Sefer had close to 90 colocation customers by May 2022, and Wingu Africa's WCX platform provides local cloud that interoperates with Azure and AWS (2025); Wingu raised commercial finance in 2025 to accelerate its rollout across Ethiopia, Djibouti and Tanzania. Entry is not gated by an individual licence: data centre and hosting service provision sit among the class licences of Directive 792/2021, alongside ISP, virtual ISP, VSAT and satellite categories.

On the state's own side, government security and artificial intelligence bodies run on cloud infrastructure the state built itself (December 2025), and the national identity system runs across data-centre sites of its own (July 2026). Where government data actually sits is not a matter of public record: the hosting arrangements behind the government cloud are not published (2025).

Energy

The grid delivers an average of 39 interruptions a month, with about 21 hours of outage a month, to smart-metered users, and households on the low-voltage network face more (2025). Access to electricity reached about 55 per cent of the population in 2023, split 94.7 per cent urban against 43.6 per cent rural in the same year, and Ethiopia's Access to Energy score of 30.5 out of 100 in 2023 ranks 32nd of 54 African states despite a 16.6-point gain over the decade.

The off-grid half of the plan is behind. The National Electrification Programme 2.0 set a 65 per cent grid and 35 per cent off-grid split for 2025, and progress has been slower than planned, an EU co-funded programme installed five solar mini-grids between 2017 and 2024, and the World Bank's US$500 million ADELE electrification project lost US$70 million in a July 2024 restructuring, with cost overruns meaning its planned 201 mini-grids will not all be built. Deployments in the field work around the gap rather than wait for it to close: the Ministry of Health issued roughly 29,950 power banks alongside tablets to Health Extension Workers (2023) so the community health information system could run where mains power is not available.

Price is moving too. After the October 2025 revision the Ethiopian Electric Utility charges 0.76 birr per kWh for the first 50 kWh block, rising to 5.10 birr per kWh above 500 kWh, a phased move to cost recovery from tariffs that had been among the world's lowest. Almost all output is renewable, at 99.96 per cent in 2015, which ties supply to rainfall: Ethiopian Electric Power cut the electricity it supplies to bitcoin and other data-mining customers by about 75 per cent, to around 23 per cent of contracted volumes, as reservoir levels fell ahead of the dry season (September 2026). Networks are where the money is going, with Agence Française de Développement committing a EUR 80 million concessional loan in 2024 to modernise Ethiopian Electric Power's networks for a more digitalised economy, inside a co-financed package with the EIB, the French Treasury and EU grants.

Technical Capacity

The state's own digital delivery arm is losing the argument for its people: MESOB is losing staff to better-paying institutions, with the attrition unresolved (July 2026), and the three-year plan it launched on 24 July 2026 makes strengthening institutional capacity one of its central goals. The pool it draws from is not obviously the constraint — GitHub counted more than 94,000 developers in Ethiopia in 2023, up 32 per cent year on year — but holding a share of that pool inside government is.

Where the state has built in-house, it has done so as a stated choice. The National ID Program runs on the open-source MOSIP platform and staffs the system's engineering itself (July 2026), and its executive director argues that governments must understand what is inside identity systems rather than buy black-box turnkey projects. The security agency has built a government email client deployed across federal institutions, with its own messaging and meeting platforms in rollout and pilot, to replace foreign applications in public service (July 2025). That model has been tested: national health information systems on DHIS2, which Ethiopia runs nationwide, were reported still online and supported by local staff after the 2025 United States aid cuts.

Handover from implementers is being attempted rather than assumed. The aLIVE programme worked inside the Ministry of Agriculture's ICT unit for four years and placed three interns there when routine ICT tasks were found to be consuming the core staff time needed for system design and data governance, and a dedicated data steward now coordinates the Livestock Information System across directorates (July 2026). Against that, general administrative capability sits mid-table: an Effective Administration score of 59.6 out of 100 in 2023, 20th of 54 African states.

Cybersecurity

Ethiopia now has a cybersecurity statute that does not yet bind: the Critical Infrastructure Cyber Security Protection Proclamation No. 1426/2026, signed on 21 July 2026, enters into force one year after its publication in the Federal Negarit Gazette. It designates twelve critical infrastructure sectors, places 18 core cybersecurity obligations on their owners and operators and establishes a Critical Infrastructure Cybersecurity Fund. The Council of Ministers adopted a revised national cybersecurity policy, effective 27 June 2024, setting out the areas for public-private partnership and guidelines for implementing, monitoring and following it up; the earlier framework on record is the National Cyber Security Framework of 2014.

On declared arrangements the country scores well, in Tier 2, Advancing, of the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024 — a measure of commitments and institutions rather than of tested defences. Statutory duties have caught up faster than strategy: the 2024 data protection proclamation requires controllers to notify the regulator and the people affected within 72 hours of learning of a breach, and to document every breach. Cybersecurity frameworks are one of the four workstreams of the World Bank's US$200 million Digital Foundations project, running 2021 to 2026. A financial sector cybersecurity forum, jointly chaired by the information security agency and the central bank, was established on 29 September 2026 for threat-information sharing and coordinated incident response. Five mandatory cybersecurity standards and 31 guidelines were approved in April 2026 to give the critical-infrastructure proclamation technical effect, and the security agency has run a public key infrastructure since 31 August 2024, acting as root certificate authority for certificates issued to national institutions and private companies.

Assurance lags the estate it covers. Independent third-party security and software code audits of the national digital identity system are funded work under the World Bank project rather than work already completed (2025).

DPI

Data Exchange

Ethiopia has no operational whole-of-government exchange layer: data remains fragmented across agencies for want of clear data-sharing rules and standards, the one-stop government platform began as a federal pilot integrating twelve institutions (2025), and the Ethiopia Digital Stack exchange platform funded under the World Bank digital ID project has yet to be delivered (2024).

What does move between systems moves around that gap. The SIGTAS tax administration system is linked to the trade ministry's document authentication and registration service and to the national ID office to verify corporate and individual taxpayers (2025), and five core systems — financial management, customs, tax administration, public-service HR and e-procurement — exchange data both through direct point-to-point interfaces and through a Government Service Bus (2025).

The standards have been settled for years without the plumbing beneath them. The Ethiopian eGovernment Interoperability Framework sets the cross-agency data-sharing rules and establishes Regional Cells that act as ministry-level chief interoperability officers, and that framework is one of the few things of its kind in place: most of the supporting measures the GovTech index tests alongside it are recorded as absent (2025). In the health sector, standards and interoperability sit at the middle "defined" stage of the national DHIS2 deployment, with automated patient data exchange between DHIS2 and other systems not yet implemented (2024).

Integration is meanwhile being improvised. Two competing integration models have emerged under the one-stop platform: in Addis Ababa it has absorbed institutions' systems, while in the regions it stays tethered to their separate systems and users are bounced between the platform and the institutions (July 2026), and at the same meeting a prime-ministerial board's approval of a national data exchange platform was disclosed — approved rather than built. Sectoral harmonisation is running ahead of the national layer: five separate livestock databases are being aligned to an international data standard under a four-year programme with the Ministry of Agriculture (2024).

Digital Identity and CRVS

Fayda enrolment reached 49.1 million people by 24 August 2026, on 12,000 biometric registration kits deployed nationwide, while 13 million cards had been printed by mid-2026 — registration and credential are not the same count. Targets have run ahead of delivery throughout: 23 million IDs had been issued by October 2025 against a target of 63 million by the end of that year.

Proclamation No. 1284/2023 established the National ID Program's digital identification system, with enrolment rights, data protection principles, relying-party rules and criminal penalties for fraud. Enrolment is formally voluntary, though relying parties may make it mandatory with their regulator's approval, and Fayda has been made mandatory for new bank accounts, tax identification numbers, property and notary transactions, SIM registration and student enrolment for national examinations (October 2025), having been made the main credential for all civil servants in 2023. The National Bank required Fayda for all new bank accounts nationwide from January 2026; unlinked Commercial Bank of Ethiopia accounts in Addis Ababa, Dire Dawa, the Harari Region and 24 other cities have since been placed under debit restrictions, and the bank gave customers everywhere else until 9 November 2026 to link theirs (September 2026). Addis Ababa announced in January 2025 that the credential would replace the birth certificate for school registration from the following academic year.

The register is in heavy use. The programme reports more than 194 million eKYC verifications performed against the register to date (August 2026), against the 32.3 million successful authentications, around 130,000 a day, that the World Bank's implementation review recorded by October 2025 — and more than 150 agencies run KYC checks against the register (July 2026), with over five million tax identification numbers harmonised with Fayda (October 2025).

Enrolment itself has been contracted out to the telecoms sector. Ethio Telecom accounts for 69 per cent of all registrations, about 32 million people since April 2024, and Safaricom Ethiopia has been added as a second telco-led channel (July 2026). Refugees and asylum seekers have been brought into the system since a pilot launched in Addis Ababa in March 2024, and a refugee holding the credential can open a bank account, register a SIM and obtain a tax number without the case-by-case endorsement letters previously required; children under five remain outside the

system. The programme runs three data centres with more than 50 in-house engineers and charges relying parties authentication fees, and in August 2026 it was inaugurated as Faydaverse, a state-owned enterprise under the sovereign holding company Ethiopian Investment Holdings. The enterprise began charging banks 10 to 20 birr a record retrieval and 20 to 40 birr a biometric authentication, and the bankers' association asked for a consultation with the central bank, reported 3 October 2026. A trade publication reported a public developer sandbox opened for the digital identity, which counted more than 52 million registrations and 208 million electronic verifications at 9 October 2026.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Ethiopia's payment volumes and its payment users have come apart. Telebirr carried 4.19 trillion Birr across 2.61 billion transactions and 60.6 million customers in the 2025/26 fiscal year, yet only about a third of adults used digital payments in 2024, on the 2025 Global Findex. Digital accounts multiplied 2.3-fold to 222.1 million by March 2025 while formal account ownership barely moved, and more than 135 million mobile wallets have been opened while fewer than one adult in ten holds a mobile money account and 0.4 per cent rely on one as their only financial account, and an assessment of the second financial inclusion strategy counts 157.6 million mobile money accounts at June 2026, 29.56 per cent of them active (September 2026). The central bank put digital financial transactions at 33 trillion birr in the 2025/26 fiscal year.

The rails are now largely built. EthSwitch launched EthioPay-IPS, the national instant payment system, in December 2025, connecting 32 banks, 12 microfinance institutions, three payment system operators and three payment instrument issuers for real-time account-to-account, wallet, QR and bulk payments, and it passed 1 million peer-to-peer transactions in a single day in May 2026. The switch processed 287.4 million transactions worth 741.1 billion Birr in 2024/25, person-to-person transfers overtaking ATM withdrawals. The National Bank co-owns EthSwitch with 33 payment providers, its vice governor chairs the switch's board of bank chief executives, and it provides oversight and approvals rather than operating the switch (2025). The national switch presented a unified government payment platform at a finance forum that closed on 1 October 2026, a single interoperable route for government bill payments by app, ATM, USSD, branch and agent; no volume or rollout timetable is published.

Competition has not dislodged the incumbent. M-PESA Ethiopia reported 2.58 million 30-day active customers and 89,877 merchants in the quarter to 30 June 2026, and accounts for roughly 2 per cent of Safaricom Ethiopia's service revenue against 45.6 per cent in Kenya. Mobile money is thin margin on both sides: Telebirr generated 3.6 per cent of Ethio Telecom's revenue in 2025/26 despite being its largest platform by customers.

Regulation is restrictive. The National Bank confirmed on 23 July 2026 that its prohibition covers the whole category of virtual assets, not only cryptocurrencies, by clarification of existing rules rather than new regulation and with no enforcement mechanism announced. Revenue authorities froze and swept the accounts of the payment gateways Arifpay, Chapa and Santimpay in May 2026 over disputed tax claims, in a gateway sector where online sports betting accounts for almost all volume (2025). Government-to-person payments are meanwhile shifting to electronic transfer across safety-net programmes reaching more than 9 million people (March 2024). A licensed payment-system operator and an international card scheme signed a framework agreement to roll out 148,000 contactless acceptance devices to merchants, certified as tax cash registers. The central bank and the operator of the pan-African payment and settlement system announced Ethiopia's membership on 15 October 2026, letting its financial institutions connect for cross-border payments, and non-bank wallets and payment providers are preparing to connect, each needing a central bank no-objection letter first (October 2026).

Awash Bank and Oromia Bank launched international payment cards on 8 October 2026, eight months after the central bank's amendment of 11 February 2026 let authorised banks issue internationally accepted cards to foreign-currency account holders.

Registries

More than 50.5 million voters registered for the 7th General Election by the close of registration on 22 April 2026, of whom just over 5.5 million used the Fayda-linked digital channel — the remainder registered manually. The digital channel is Mirchaye, the electoral board's web and mobile self-registration system launched in January 2026, which uses Fayda data and is offered at selected polling stations.

Behind it sits the identity register: Fayda, a foundational legal ID established under Proclamation No. 1284/2023, holds core demographic data and fingerprint, iris and facial biometrics (2026). Civil registration remains its weakest joint. Births, deaths, marriages, divorce and adoption are covered nationwide under Proclamation No. 760/2012 as amended, through a decentralised structure running from federal to kebele level on a nationally mandated paper process, with digital capture piloted in Addis Ababa, Oromia and Amhara (2025); vital-events forms pass up from kebele to woreda and on to federal and regional offices. Registrations of children under one reached around 40 per cent of estimated live births in 2022/23, excluding Tigray, and there was no data linkage between the civil registration system and the national identity system (July 2025).

The functional registers are further ahead. The trade ministry delivered more than 2.9 million business registration and licensing services online in the first nine months of 2025/26, after an integrated company creation service launched in September 2025, drawing on the revenue ministry, the national identification agency and document verification offices, cut registration from 11 steps and up to 32 days to two steps and two days on the ministry's own account. The taxpayer register is computerised, centralised and gives a full countrywide view of individual and business taxpayers (2025). Land is the outlier: the eLand digital land administration platform lists three cities using it, Bishoftu, Adama and Shagar (2025), while the digital addressing system had been implemented in 73 cities by December 2025 and a national farmer database is being joined to Fayda and rural land information systems, initially across 311 woredas (2025).

Sectoral management information systems

The Federal Auditor General reported in July 2026 budget-execution gaps and weak financial controls across several federal agencies despite their adoption of digital systems, alongside billions of Birr left uncollected through persistent shortcomings in revenue administration.

The core systems exist. An integrated financial management information system built on commercial software is in use across central and local government, a custom-built customs system and payroll system are in use, tax administration runs on a hybrid of custom and commercial software, and the public-service HR system has most of its services digitised (2025); social insurance is split, with public employees served by a separate pension and social insurance system from the general one. Customs declarations run through the eCMS electronic customs management system, and a nationwide point-based traffic penalty system launched in 2025 with API integration to financial institutions. An e-filing system is in use among large and medium taxpayers, with challenges still holding back its adoption (January 2024).

Health is the deepest deployment and shows what depth is worth. DHIS2 has been the national health information system since 2018, with automated reporting implemented at all health facilities, yet the deployment scored 2.81 out of 5 against the country's own 2025 target of 4.09. The community health information system was running in more than 7,500 health posts, with more than 20 million people registered through it (2025), under half of the country's 17,903 health posts; health workers report carrying parallel paper and electronic records and personal liability for lost devices.

Education is digitising its records while most schools lack power: digitisation of the education management information system was completed in 2024/25, and only 31.8 per cent of primary and middle schools had electricity, and a DHIS2-based education data system begun with UNICEF in November 2025 works with schools, woreda offices and zonal departments in four regions. The health ministry announced deployment of electronic medical information systems across 130 health facilities (2025).

A 2025 review of the property-tax system records that it was built in 2016 for three pilot cities and never fully implemented, and sets out a roadmap for national scale-up.

The revenue ministry re-advertised on 8 October 2026 for a technical lead to govern the system's architecture, oversee vendors and integrate it with its data warehouse and e-invoicing systems, with expressions of interest due 29 October. The e-invoicing side already runs: an electronic invoice management system built by the security agency for the revenue ministry was inaugurated on 8 October 2024.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

MESOB's founding director general conceded in July 2026 that the one-stop platform remains intertwined with institutions' systems, some decades old and built to undefined standards, and regional officials told federal management that services are being onboarded before the underlying institutional systems have been digitised, the platform's Addis Ababa deputy director naming that premature integration one of the year's major hurdles. Its three-year plan launched on 24 July 2026 makes strengthening institutional capacity one of its central goals, against staff losses to better-paying institutions that management has not resolved.

What the platform actually offers is narrower than the ambition. The platform's own public catalogue lists 180+ services from 23 named provider organisations, each with its required documents, processing time and fees (August 2026). Behind the front door sit Fayda as the authentication layer and passport, tax registration, investment and work-permit services with a MESOB Bridge API gateway for real-time data sharing between agencies (2025).

Elsewhere in the estate, delivery is real but uneven. The national service portal is transactional at level 3 or 4, meaning services can be applied for and completed online end to end, and a public jobs portal and an e-procurement system covering open tendering and contract management are in use, while the social protection portal is still being implemented (2025). Federal procurement became fully electronic in the Ethiopian fiscal year to July 2025, when the system handled 308.75 billion birr across 169 federal budget institutions and 93 branch offices, up from 65 per cent of procurement the year before. The Auditor General attributed a decline in cash shortages across federal institutions largely to the e-procurement system, saying it has strengthened procurement oversight and budget administration (July 2026). A Federal Supreme Court directive brought electronic filing and remote hearings to federal courts from November 2025, with a national ID number required to use the platform, and an unmanned "smart police station" staffed by AI kiosks had opened by March 2026. Against all of it, Ethiopia scored 0.3111 on the UN E-Government Development Index, 169th of 193 member states (2024).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The digital one-stop state below the federal level is, for now, one city. Addis Ababa runs 11 one-stop service centres and is extending access through mobile service units, with more than 150 services from more than 25 institutions integrated into one system under its Addis Mesob programme (July 2026).

The capital's approach and the regions' have already diverged, into two competing integration models: in Addis Ababa MESOB has absorbed institutions' systems, while in the regions it stays tethered to their separate systems and users are bounced between the platform and the institutions (July 2026). MESOB began as a federal pilot of 12 institutions and 41 services meant as a model for nationwide expansion, and the route by which interoperability is meant to reach regional administrations at all is the interoperability framework's Regional Cells, which act as ministry-level chief interoperability officers.

What does exist below the federal level is mostly back-office rather than counter-facing. The integrated financial management system in use covers local as well as central government (2025). A DHIS2-based education data system begun with UNICEF in November 2025 works with schools, woreda education offices and zonal departments in four regions. The digital addressing system is being practically implemented in 73 cities, with work begun in Arba Minch, Jinka and Wolayita Sodo (December 2025), and the eLand land administration platform lists three cities using it, Bishoftu, Adama and Shagar (2025). The pattern is consistent: regional states and woredas appear in these systems as sources of data flowing upward, and rarely as the level at which a citizen meets a digital service.

Rural digital data capture

Outside Addis Ababa the state's most extensive digital record-keeping is done by health workers rather than by offices: an offline-first mobile application on tablets carried into communities captures household health data at the point of contact, and the health ministry has had to issue power banks alongside the tablets so it works where there is no mains supply. It had been adopted at 7,808 of the country's 17,903 health posts, under half (2025).

Elsewhere in the rural service network the medium is paper. Civil registration at kebele level is recorded on paper vital-events forms, copies of which pass up to woreda, federal and regional offices.

Agriculture is where the position is moving, and the newest money is behind the extension worker rather than the office. FAO began a project running to 2028 to turn a start-up initiative in digitally enabled pluralistic extension into a long-term programme, tying agricultural productivity to nutrition, food security and health outcomes (2026). Alongside it, farmer registration is being joined to the digital ID and to rural land information systems in a woreda-level pilot, identity enrolment now reaches into the woredas, and safety-net cash transfers have moved from physical to electronic payment.

The setting is not a uniformly weak one. Rural economy is Ethiopia's strongest governance sub-category, 66.6 out of 100 and 20th of 54 African states, led by rural market access at 85.0 and third on the continent (2023). Within it, though, rural land and water access fell 9.1 points over the decade to 44.4 and 36th place, and rural representation and participation fell 2.8 points to 63.1 (2023) — the two measures closest to what a land or extension record is meant to serve.

Technology

AI

The largest identified sum behind Ethiopian artificial intelligence in government is foreign: the United Kingdom committed about GBP 4.5 million over 2025-2029 to a specialist facility giving technical assistance to Ethiopian public bodies on the use of appropriate AI models, with local skills-building, aimed at healthcare, education and government administration (2025).

Domestic policy came first. A National AI Policy was adopted in 2024, sitting alongside Digital Ethiopia 2030's prioritisation of the field, and Council of Ministers Regulation 510/2022 established the Artificial Intelligence Institute, transferring to it the rights of the earlier AI Research and Development Center. UNESCO's completed readiness assessment finds no binding law yet on the public procurement of AI systems, algorithmic transparency or liability for AI-induced harm (2026).

What is actually running is small. An unmanned police station staffed by AI kiosks and open around the clock had opened by March 2026. A national data exchange paired with a predictive model has been approved rather than built (July 2026), leaving the interoperability layer beneath any government-wide AI still to be assembled.

ICT Industry

Ethiopia's technology industry is a state operator, one foreign entrant and a thin domestic tail. The entrant is growing fast: Safaricom Ethiopia's service revenue rose 54.2 per cent to KSh 9.68 billion for the quarter to December 2025, though its mobile money arm contributes a fraction of what the same product earns the same operator in Kenya (June 2026). Ethio Telecom remains the larger business by a wide margin, with revenue growth of a third in the 2025/26 fiscal year and data overtaking voice as its largest single earner in the same year. It sold a slice of itself to the public: the deadline for its 10 per cent initial public offering, subscribed through Telebirr, was extended to 14 February 2025.

Equipment and platforms are bought abroad. At MWC 2026 Ethio Telecom signed network expansion agreements with Ericsson, ZTE, Huawei and Nokia, and the structure of the market is settled at the licensing counter, where the Communications Authority must approve in advance any change in shareholding that takes a holder to 25 per cent or more, and refuse it where it judges the acquisition anti-competitive.

Domestic firms exist and are exposed. Better Auth raised a US$5 million seed round in June 2025 for open-source authentication technology, while the revenue authority froze and swept the accounts of domestic payment gateways in May 2026 over a tax claim the firms dispute. The regulatory environment has nonetheless improved on the measure: Ethiopia's Business and Competition Regulations score rose 21.4 points over 2014-2023 to 61.2 out of 100, eighteenth of 54 African states.

Innovation ecosystem

Ethiopia now has a startup statute. The Startup Proclamation 1396/2025, gazetted on 2 September 2025, creates a designation for startups and for "ecosystem builders", a digital startup portal, a national designation committee, a startup grant programme, a credit-guarantee fund and a fund of funds. It sits against a base ranked 134th in the 2025 Global Innovation Index, down from 130th in 2024.

Inside government the picture is an institution without a plan: Ethiopia has an established public-sector innovation institution working on digital skills and public-service innovation, but no public-sector innovation strategy or programme for it to work to (2025). Public-private collaboration is one of its stated mechanisms, and a startup or innovation programme is in place alongside supporting schemes.

The money that builds hubs and incubators is external and time-limited. Korea granted US$10 million over 2020-2026, delivered with UNDP, to support ICT startups and SMEs in Addis Ababa, establish innovation clusters linking universities and industry, develop the legal frameworks for commercialising science and technology, and build an innovation fund. UNDP is separately running the Ethiopian component of its timbuktoo pan-African start-up initiative over 2024-2026 with about US$1.7 million, a blended facility for startups in fintech, agritech and digital entrepreneurship, and a further programme of about US$3.7 million over 2022-2026 for SME innovation and digital finance. All three windows close in 2026.

Absorption shows in individual firms rather than in aggregate. The e-mobility firm Dodai closed a US$13 million Series A in April 2026, US$8 million of equity and US$5 million of debt, and Better Auth closed a US$5 million seed round in June 2025. Nothing yet records a startup designated under the new proclamation or a grant made from its fund.

Capacity

Literacy

More Ethiopian children are finishing school, but no more of them are starting: the Ibrahim Index scores Education Completion at 36.6 out of 100, 26th of 54 African states and up 10.5 points over the decade to 2023, against an Education Enrolment score of 32.4, 37th and effectively flat at plus 1.0 points (2023).

Quality moved the other way over the same period. Education Quality fell 4.9 points to 40.3 out of 100, 31st of 54, even as Human Resources in Education stayed one of Ethiopia's strongest measures at 83.0 (2023) — the teachers are there and the schooling they deliver is rated worse than it was.

Most primary and middle schools have no power: only 31.8 per cent of primary and middle schools had electricity in 2024/25.

What has changed is the paperwork at the classroom door. Addis Ababa announced in January 2025 that the Fayda digital ID would replace the birth certificate as the document required to register a child for school from the following academic year, following the migration of student biometric records to issue Fayda-based student IDs and the completion of integration testing for student identity by the Ministry of Education and the National ID Program (2025). Enrolling in school now depends on holding a credential rather than on reading one.

Training and skills

Ethiopia has a digital skills strategy for the public service and a freely available training programme delivering it, but the content covers basic digital skills and data literacy rather than advanced skills (2025). The state is training its staff to use systems, not to build them.

External money for skills is substantial and long-dated. The European Union committed EUR 14 million over 2024-2032 to digital skills development in the technical and vocational education and training system (2024), as part of a stated 360-degree approach to digital transformation. The UK's EthiopiAI programme runs 2025-2029 and funds a specialist facility giving technical assistance to Ethiopian public sector bodies alongside local skills-building, aimed at healthcare, education and government administration, and the World Bank's Digital Foundations Project carries digital skills as one component beside broadband, digital government platforms and cybersecurity, closing in 2026. The government's flagship coder programme is now the 7 Million Coders initiative (August 2026); no enrolment or completion figure is held. The Mastercard Foundation's Young Africa Works programme counts digital skills, agritech, fintech and digital jobs among its sectors and targets dignified work for 10 million young Ethiopians by 2030 (2023).

Below that, individual systems train the people who have to run them. More than 300 Ethiopian experts and data collectors have been trained on the National Livestock Data Standards through a training-of-trainers cascade the Ministry of Agriculture owns, with training continuing toward nationwide adoption (July 2026).

Training is not the only thing missing. Health workers using the electronic community health information system name the burden of parallel paper and electronic recording, and fear of personal liability for stolen devices, among the barriers to using it, alongside poor training (2023). Nor is the wider technical workforce the shortage: Ethiopia's developer population is large and was growing fast in 2023, and teacher and staff provision is among the country's strongest education scores (2023) while the quality of what is taught has slipped.

Research institutions

The institutional machinery meant to lift Ethiopia's research base is largely donor-built, and its funding windows close together: KOICA granted US$10 million over 2020-2026, delivered with UNDP, to establish innovation clusters linking universities and industry, develop policy and legal frameworks for science and technology commercialisation, and build an innovation fund (2020), against an innovation ranking close to the bottom of the global table (2025).

Research on Ethiopia's own digital systems is produced and published. An index of whether health facilities actually use their HMIS data for local decisions, applied across 305 facilities, rose from 7.2 to 7.9 between 2019 and 2020, and a systematic review of Ethiopian digital-payment literature published since 2015 places trust ahead of convenience, speed, security and cost as the factor connecting service provision to user satisfaction (August 2026).

The instruments used to judge the systems come from outside. The National ID Program has adopted the Digital Impact Alliance's Digital ID Assessment as one of its official monitoring mechanisms, first run in early 2025 and re-run in 2026.

Inclusion

Access to services

Ethiopia's equal access to public services scores 19.0 out of 100 (2023), 47th of 54 African states and among its ten worst governance indicators, up only 2.2 points over the decade — the evenness of service delivery is the one thing here that has barely moved. Access for women, at 23.6 out of 100 and 43rd of 54 (2023), is better only in direction: up 15.8 points since 2014.

Identity is now the gate on most transactions. Fayda enrolment is formally voluntary but mandatory for a new bank account, a SIM, a tax number and enrolment for national examinations (October 2025), while enrolment had reached 49.1 million (24 August 2026) — the requirement is running ahead of the credential. Registration and the number are free; a printed card carries a fee. For refugees it works the other way, replacing the case-by-case endorsement letters previously needed for the same services (2025).

Provision for people with disabilities is led by the operator: telebirr offers IVR, USSD and voice-command access and Ethio Telecom discounts connectivity by up to 35 per cent for them (2025). The federal ombudsman takes administrative complaints, with status tracking, and freedom-of-information requests through an online portal (October 2026).

Where a transfer is the service, the account is the point of access. The Productive Safety Net Programme's fifth phase targets around 8 million people (2025), and its transfers have been moving to electronic payment. Bank-account ownership rose from 22 per cent in 2014 to about 45 per cent in 2020 on central bank figures, and the revised national financial-inclusion strategy targeted 70 per cent by 2025; it has since moved very little, leaving Ethiopia far short of the average for low- and middle-income countries (2024).

The physical counter is being consolidated: Addis Ababa runs one-stop service centres and mobile units that bring more than 25 institutions' services into one system (July 2026). For the online version the device is the barrier: Ethio Telecom puts smartphone penetration at roughly 36 per cent, and has secured 15 billion birr of financing from Siinqee Bank, four billion of it earmarked for low-income users' handsets, towards 2.6 million devices in the coming financial year (September 2026).

Digital divides

Ethiopia's digital divide tracks rural electrification, which trails urban supply by a wide margin, and it is wider than headline connectivity suggests, because unique subscriber penetration and internet use both run far below the SIM counts usually quoted. On the device side the constraint is price: high handset costs and limited supply are holding back smartphone uptake, with Ethio Telecom looking to local production to widen reach (2025).

Women are behind on every line of this the record carries. Ethiopia sits among the countries with a large gender gap in mobile internet use (2023), and the Fayda programme has prioritised registering women (August 2026) and serves people without smartphones through custodian wallets managed by authorised agents (2025). Women's access to public services remains among the weaker records in Africa, though it has improved over the decade.

Two instruments now exist to act on the distribution rather than describe it. Ethio Telecom and Safaricom Ethiopia are required to contribute 1.5 per cent of revenue to the Universal Access Fund (March 2026), which gives the state a standing source of finance against the divide instead of an appropriation to be argued for each year. And Article 6 of Directive 792/2021 allows the Communications Authority to exempt services from licensing altogether after stakeholder consultation, naming community networks and not-for-profit or social-purpose organisations — a legal route for locally owned networks in places no operator will serve commercially.

Data

National statistics

The statistical system is being re-founded in law. Parliament approved an Ethiopian Statistical Service Proclamation on 30 June 2026, intended to strengthen the service's independence and align the national statistical system with international statistical principles, after the Council of Ministers referred the draft on 26 May 2026; no gazette text had been published when this was compiled. The planning instrument has not kept pace: the second National Strategy for the Development of Statistics ran to 2019/20, and in its place the planning ministry and the statistics service launched a three-year statistical development programme in February 2024, with economic, agricultural and population and housing censuses, costed at about ETB 35 billion to 2026 and holding the population census to its final year pending stability.

Collection is where the system is thinnest. The statistics service's own account is that three national censuses have been held — 1984, 1994 and 2007 — and that current population figures are projections from the 2007 count. Ethiopia has held neither an agricultural census nor a business census in the past twenty years — an absence that matters in a country whose economy and workforce are largely agricultural. The survey programme is thinner in the same place: three or more agricultural, business, health and household surveys have been run in the past ten years, but only two labour force surveys (2023).

The World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators put Ethiopia's weakest pillars at data sources and data infrastructure, both in the 20-49% band, while data use and data products score 70-89% and data services 50-69% (2023). The state is better at using and presenting numbers than at collecting them, which is the harder end to fix.

Measured against the continent rather than against a standard, the picture reads more favourably: Ethiopia's Capacity of the Statistical System score reached 63.4 out of 100 in 2023, tenth of 54 African states, after a 12.4-point rise over 2014-2023.

Administrative sources carry much of the load left by the survey and census gaps, and they are uneven. The health system's national reporting platform is in place across the health estate, but its maturity assessment falls short of the government's own 2025 target (2024), and a facility-level index found only a small rise in whether facilities actually use the data they report (2020). Civil registration runs nationwide in law but records only a minority of births (2023). Where administrative registers are strongest — the computerised, centralised taxpayer database (2025) and the Ministry of Trade's digital trader database (May 2024) — no denominator is published alongside them, so they count records rather than measure coverage. The Federal Auditor General presented an annual audit report on federal public institutions to parliament on 6 July 2026.

Open data

Ethiopia's open data policy is the 2016 EITI Open Data Policy, an extractive-industries transparency instrument held in the Ministry of Innovation and Technology's policy library, with a national data strategy still planned rather than adopted (2025). The open data portal carries only basic information and datasets and is updated largely by hand rather than automatically from the systems that hold the data (2025).

Population and vital statistics score 2 out of 10 in the 2024 Open Data Inventory, the lowest of Ethiopia's assessed categories carrying a score.

Nineteen of the 23 categories scored in that inventory sit between 3 and 5 out of 10, with labour statistics the only one above that band, at 5.5, and pollution and digital and telecommunications statistics at zero.

Documents that exist often stay inside. Across five parts of the digital government estate, from the service portal and e-procurement to the participation and feedback channels, documentation and assessments are held internally and not published (2025). Nothing is published on how the right-to-information regime performs or on how the data protection regime operates (2025).

Individual institutions are writing exemptions that are hard to reverse. The Development Bank of Ethiopia's Information Disclosure Policy puts internal strategy papers, legal case files, classified communications, security protocols and third-party contracts alongside client credit information in a permanently non-declassifiable category, and lets it refuse any request requiring it to create or collect data it does not already hold (8 August 2026).

Against that, Ethiopia's Disclosure of Public Records score rose 23.3 points over 2014-2023 to 44.0 out of 100, fourteenth of 54 African states and its fourth most improved indicator, and Accessibility of Public Records stands at 37.4, eighteenth of 54 (2023) — top-third placings on scores still below half marks.

Use of satellite data

The Ethiopian Communications Authority stated in July 2025 that no discussions with Starlink had taken place, were under way or were planned, which makes the position on satellite broadband entry one of no application filed rather than an application refused. The Space Science and Geospatial Institute has built the Ethiopian Digital Addressing System, in practical implementation in 73 cities (December 2025). No published national programme applies Earth observation data to agriculture, land administration or environmental management as at August 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The American position in Ethiopia has been rewritten from paying for a health data system to helping build one Ethiopia then pays to run. The December 2025 memorandum of understanding under the America First Global Health Strategy sets out United States funding for Ethiopian health data systems on a declining schedule to 2030, with Ethiopia undertaking to meet the software licensing, cloud, hardware maintenance and replacement costs itself. That succeeds a far larger and differently shaped commitment: USAID put about US$60 million into the Ethiopia Digital Health Activity over 2020-2025, building on the national eHealth strategy and supporting DHIS2, OpenMRS and the interoperability layer between them.

What that transition costs is partly answerable already, because Ethiopia has been through a version of it. National DHIS2 health information systems, Ethiopia's nationwide deployment among them, were reported still online on local staff after the 2025 United States aid cuts, while donor-funded project systems such as PEPFAR's global HIV database were shut down (April 2025).

China activities

The vendor relationships that built Ethio Telecom's network are being pushed up the stack into the layers where the data sits. The operator and Huawei are discussing extending a network-equipment relationship into cloud, AI, cybersecurity, IoT, data-centre services and digital platforms for businesses, together with local software development, solution customisation and system integration (July 2026). The same discussions reach telebirr, covering integration for payments and e-commerce and the financing of smartphone affordability (July 2026) — which would carry one supplier from the radio network through to the payment instrument and the handset it runs on, inside a state-owned operator that is also the country's dominant mobile money provider.

On the network itself the work is advancing. Ethio Telecom signed expansion agreements with Ericsson, ZTE, Huawei and Nokia at MWC 2026 (March 2026) under its Next Horizon strategy, and ZTE has since completed work at 879 sites, across RAN modernisation, microwave-link upgrades and IP RAN (August 2026). The two are also exploring device financing, to turn coverage into handsets, and are working together on renewable-energy supply under Ethio Telecom's Green Operator programme.

EU activities

The largest European position in Ethiopia's digital economy is not a digital project. Agence Française de Développement committed a EUR 80 million sovereign concessional loan in 2024 to modernise Ethiopian Electric Power's networks for a more digitalised economy, inside a co-financed package with the European Investment Bank (EUR 83m), the French Treasury (EUR 55m and above) and EU grants (EUR 40m) — power for the digital economy rather than the digital economy itself.

The European Union appears more often than any other financier in Ethiopia's digital record, and it does so by number of commitments rather than by value (2026).

Frequency is not weight. The Commission's own commitments are small and spread across the state: EUR 1.2 million over 2020-2025 to the Ministry of Innovation and Technology for its role guiding digital reforms under the Ease of Doing Business programme; about EUR 1.35 million of technical assistance over 2021-2024 to build a health insurance information system for the Ethiopian Health Insurance Agency, covering both the social and the community-based schemes; and almost EUR 5 million over 2023-2027 to help financial service providers reach

micro, small and medium enterprises in the conflict-affected north, where lending capacity was lost. Two further strands run alongside them, countering online hate speech and incitement to 2026 and digital skills in the technical and vocational training system out to 2032.

European money has also gone in as equity rather than aid: DEG put EUR 4 million into M-BIRR in 2018, its first fintech financing anywhere in Africa, alongside the European Investment Bank and Finnfund.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state or Gulf-based company held a financing commitment, infrastructure stake or platform deployment in Ethiopia's digital sector as at August 2026.

India activities

Ethiopia's national identity system runs on Indian-incubated code. Fayda is built on MOSIP, the modular open-source identity platform licensed under MPL 2.0 and incubated at IIIT-Bangalore, and is among its furthest-advanced national deployments — a technical dependency first. The one Indian commitment on the record is a data centre: India's Ministry of External Affairs awarded RailTel Corporation of India a work order of Rs 19,83,74,494 in December 2025 to establish one inside the Ethiopian foreign ministry's building in Addis Ababa, to be executed by December 2029. In September 2026 Ethiopian officials joined a UNDP learning mission to India on its digital public infrastructure, and the national payment switch used the Global Fintech Fest in Mumbai to explore links with international payment networks as India pressed to extend its Unified Payments Interface abroad.

Digital sovereignty

Ethiopia's cyber-security agency now runs a government cloud of its own: in April 2026 INSA launched Gotera Cloud, offering infrastructure, platform, software and backup services to institutions and presented as keeping citizens' and institutions' data within the country's borders, under a Digital Ethiopia 2030 strategy that includes the establishment of a sovereign government cloud (December 2025). The rule beneath it covers personal data: since July 2024 controllers and processors must store locally collected personal data on servers in Ethiopia. Which workloads the government cloud carries is not public, its hosting arrangements being held internally (2025).

The identity layer is the state's to change: Fayda runs on the open-source MOSIP platform with its engineering staffed in-house (July 2026), and its operator is a state-owned enterprise inside the sovereign holding company (August 2026). The payment switch is co-owned by the National Bank and 33 payment providers (2025). Whether the state holds the source code and operating skills for the payment switch, or can exit its operating contract, was not on record as at September 2026.

The December 2025 health memorandum with the United States is published, and rests personal-data protection on each side's domestic law, runs its data-sharing arrangement two years beyond the 2030 term, and requires that arrangement to be compatible with Ethiopia's agreements with other countries and bodies. The terms on which Ethio Telecom's cloud, AI and data-centre collaboration with Huawei and the RailTel-built data centre in the foreign ministry govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

For AI, the Artificial Intelligence Institute's director general set out plans for sovereign cloud infrastructure, a national data lakehouse and indigenous multilingual models, so that national data is stored, governed and processed domestically (May 2026). Regionally, Ethiopia is one of seven states in IGAD's Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project, whose work covers data governance and cross-border data flows (January 2026).

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